

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman continues learning Ramchal, developing the idea that divine providence in a person's life is shaped by that person's choices: good deeds tend to generate conditions that facilitate further mitzvot, while misdeeds can create obstacles that make future spiritual growth harder. He addresses the fairness question—why making things harder after failure isn't a “vicious cycle”—by framing consequences as both self-inflicted and corrective: living inside the results of a false worldview ultimately teaches its emptiness and can become the very mechanism of תשובה. Rabbi Shulman then adds a crucial qualifier: Hashem judges each person “as he truly is,” factoring in pressure, capacity, intent, and circumstance, so external comparison between people is often meaningless.

I. Review: providence is shaped by human action (Ramchal)

A. The core claim being developed

- Rabbi Shulman explains that the השגחה a person experiences is impacted by his own actions.
- Good deeds can positively affect later circumstances, making it easier to do more mitzvot and continue growing.

B. Rambam on reward in “והיה אם שמוע”

- Rabbi Shulman cites Rambam's question: if the תורה promises rain, harvest, and success for listening to Hashem, is that “payment” for mitzvot?
 - Resolution: שכר מצוה בהאי עלמא ליכא—this world cannot contain the true reward for a mitzvah.
 - Therefore, the “reward” described is primarily מצוה גוררת מצוה:
 - Hashem provides opportunities and stability (financial, emotional, practical) that facilitate further עבודת ה'.
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II. When a person sins, future mitzvot can become harder (1:31)

A. The “other direction” of the principle

- Rabbi Shulman explains that mistakes and bad actions can create obstacles:
 - What used to be easy becomes challenging.
 - A person may experience more friction in spiritual life.

B. The fairness problem: why harder after failure?

- Rabbi Shulman raises the question:
 - If a person failed a test, wouldn't a good teacher make the next test easier to help him rebuild?
 - Why would Hashem allow a dynamic that seems like a "vicious cycle" of repeated failure?
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III. The corrective purpose of consequences (Ramchal in דעת תבונות; Alter of Slabodka) (3:30)

A. Ramchal's model: living inside a false belief until it collapses

- Rabbi Shulman brings Ramchal (דעת תבונות, סימן מ):
 - When a person "buys into" a false worldview, Hashem may allow him to live with its consequences.
 - The goal is experiential clarity—seeing firsthand how empty and destructive the falsehood is.

B. The outcome: the person ultimately learns the truth

- Rabbi Shulman argues this process ends with recognition that the falsehood is untrue:
 - Either in this life, or through post-life דין (including גיהנום).
- That recognition itself becomes the repair—the **discovering is the תשובה**.

C. The Alter of Slabodka: overcoming after momentum is especially transformative

- Rabbi Shulman adds the Alter's point:
 - If someone turns around *despite* accumulated momentum and habit, that reversal shows the lesson has been internalized.
 - In that area, the person can emerge stronger than before.
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IV. Adam HaRishon as the paradigm: 6,000 years to learn trust (9:30)

A. The original choice reframed

- Rabbi Shulman explains Adam HaRishon's decision as a question of trust:
 - Do you believe Hashem acts only for your good?
 - Or do you suspect there's a "better good" outside His guidance?

B. History as lived education

- Adam chose the appealing alternative, and humanity then lives through the consequences:
 - “Spend the next 6,000 years living through that experience...”
- The end goal:
 - arriving at a visceral, lived knowledge that Hashem is fully trustworthy and not withholding good.

C. Intellectual knowledge vs. experiential knowledge

- Rabbi Shulman contrasts:
 - Adam could have known it intellectually (“Hashem created me; He needs nothing; He wants my good”),
 - but humanity’s long process makes it real on a deeper level.
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V. A new case: a רשע can be enabled—or blocked (12:33)

A. Enabling success as an opening to self-destruction

- Rabbi Shulman reads Ramchal:
 - Sometimes a רשע is granted “success” specifically “לפתוח לפניו פתח האבדון שידחה בו”—to open a path of ruin.
- Examples Rabbi Shulman gives:
 - a “successful” bank robber, adulterer, or crook who keeps advancing in evil.

B. Blocking a רשע to prevent harm to others

- Rabbi Shulman explains the second possibility:
 - A רשע may be given troubles not primarily to punish him, but to stop him from carrying out a plan that would damage the world.
 - Hashem’s intervention here is for the protection of others.

C. David HaMelech’s תפילה as the model

- Rabbi Shulman quotes David’s request that Hashem prevent wicked plans from materializing:
 - “אל־תִּתֶּן ה' מֵאוֹיֵי רָשָׁע זָמְמוֹ אֶל־תִּפְּקֵ”
(“Do not grant, Hashem, the desires of the wicked; do not let his scheme be realized.”)
- Key point:
 - This is not compassion for the רשע’s spiritual welfare, but a plea to protect כלל ישראל and the innocent.

VI. Hashem's overarching governance: for the טובת כלל הברואים (17:36)

A. Hashem “judges all creatures in all their situations”

- Rabbi Shulman explains Ramchal's framing:
 - Hashem operates with “חכמתו הנפלאה,” guiding outcomes toward the best possible good for His creations.
 - He evaluates people כפי מה שהוא באמת—as it truly is.

B. Why external comparisons mislead

- Rabbi Shulman stresses that two people who “do the same thing” may not be comparable:
 - One might be in a wide-open, supported life situation and still be spiritually lazy.
 - Another might be under intense טרדות, לחץ, and hardship; his struggle changes the entire evaluation.

C. Factors Hashem accounts for

- Rabbi Shulman lists the moral/halachic variables that reshape judgment:
 - שוגג / מזיד (accidental vs. intentional)
 - אונס (coerced/forced circumstances)
 - ברצונו (voluntary choice)
 - Hashem knows the truth of:
 - “המעשים והמחשבות”—actions and thoughts—and judges accordingly.
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VII. The “bicycle” model: uphill vs. downhill avodat Hashem (18:30)

A. Rabbi Shulman's analogy

- Uphill biking:
 - hard work, real accomplishment.
- Downhill biking:
 - fast and impressive-looking, but requires less effort.

B. Applied lesson

- A person's visible accomplishments may look smaller but represent far greater struggle.
 - Another person's large visible output may be expected baseline given his circumstances.
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VIII. Practical takeaway: “inbound mitzvot,” higher expectations, and mindset (25:00)

A. “Doors opening” after growth

- Rabbi Shulman notes that people sometimes experience new openings (especially after ימים נוראים):
 - Hashem facilitates further growth when a person is doing well.

B. Growth raises the bar

- New ease/opportunity doesn't mean “now I can coast”:
 - Rabbi Shulman compares it to a sales promotion:
 - more support and better leads (“inbound”),
 - but also much higher expectations and responsibility.

C. Clarifying the healthy attitude

- Rabbi Shulman distinguishes between:
 - “I can always do better” (healthy growth orientation),
 - vs. “I'm not doing good enough” as a default (can be unhealthy unless it's truly accurate).
 - The group conversation emphasizes:
 - valuing accomplishments while still striving upward.
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In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman explains (via Ramchal and Rambam) that Hashem's “rewards” in this world often mean מצוה גוררת מצוה—conditions that enable further spiritual growth, not payment for mitzvot.
- When a person sins, Hashem may allow increased difficulty, not as a trap, but as living inside a chosen falsehood until its emptiness becomes clear—often the very engine of תשובה.
- A רשע may be granted success as a path to self-destruction, or blocked from succeeding in evil to protect others, echoed in David HaMelech's prayer: “אֵל־תִּתֶּן ה' מִאֲוִי רָשָׁע זָמְמוֹ אֶל־תִּפְקֹ”.
- Hashem judges each person “as he truly is,” factoring in pressure, intent, coercion, and circumstance—so outward comparisons are unreliable.

- Increased סייעתא דשמיא and “inbound mitzvot” raise expectations; the right mindset is to strive higher while still recognizing genuine achievements.